



Korea to mass recycle solar panels

S. Korea constructs discarded solar panel recycling center to reduce greenhouse emissions.
<https://dgit.in/jan22-53>



S. Korea's 5G users topped 20mn

The number of 5G users had topped 20 million as of November in South Korea.
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a unisex name to engrave on the outside of it, because we didn't want to know the sex of the baby. We also wanted a unisex name in case our child was transgender, because that was the extent of most parents' worries in the 2040s. I thought back to the first steps he took, even before his first birthday. The pride we felt at the complex puzzles he could do by the time he was 14 months, and the despair Ian and I felt when we were told he was severely autistic.

How difficult life was after that, as Dale got progressively worse, and fell behind every curve for kids his age. How much we would fight because of Ian's frustration and anger at feeling that he had been cheated out of being a parent. "We have none of the joys or rewards of being a parent, and we get all of the troubles, and a million more", he would say, bitter at the universe. And Dale was a frustrating child. He was violent, spoilt, self-centered and had a meltdown if the smallest thing didn't go his way. None of the therapists we'd gone to for a decade after his diagnosis had been able to help, and none of their strategies for us to cope with him had shown any improvement. Dale was just wired differently, and there was nothing anyone could do to change that.

I was always the one Dale sought comfort from, I was his mum. Tears welled up in my eyes at this point. I dared not sniff to clear my nose, so I let it all dribble out down my lips, just as Dale would.

I thought back to how the world ended 14 years ago when Dale was 12. The asteroid impact in the Indian Ocean in June. The first sightings in Sri Lanka in August. The all out devastation of India in the same month, and then the spread of attacks all over Asia, Europe and the Americas in September. We'd learnt so much about the worms in those first few months. Overnight we were all moved away from the coasts here in Australia, told to leave our cars wherever they stood while we walked or cycled everywhere. Sydney was

the first major city down under to be hit in November. Perth was the last on the second of December. That's the day my family died. Dale was unable to stay quiet, it was just impossible for him to understand the concept of danger or keeping quiet. He ran, he could not do otherwise. To my shock, Ian ran too, to try and distract the worm, in a futile effort to save Dale.

I was still angry about that. We'd discussed this at length for months. We knew that Dale would not survive if the worms attacked us. When the worms attacked us. We'd spent weeks spoiling Dale with almost every request for sweets and lollies, his favourite foods, ransacked the stores for his favourite toys. We'd said our goodbyes. Ian was the one who drilled it into me by telling me every night, "Remember, save yourself; be selfish; there's no logic in dying with Dale. We have to put ourselves first". Yet when the worm attacked, Ian left me standing there, frozen in fear and inaction, frozen because of the training he'd given me. He died uselessly, a few seconds after Dale did. He didn't even turn to look at me as that massive mouth swallowed him whole. He just dived to his death, chasing the son he thought the universe had cursed him with, leaving behind the woman he claimed life was worth living for.

The worm has retreated. Some called them Graboids because of the Tremor movies, some called them Sandworms because of the popular Dune series of books, but they were between those two in size. The largest one I'd seen, when the internet still broadcast the horror from the rest of the world, was about 10 to 12 metres long and about a meter in diameter. The one that ate my family was about that size. The few surviving humans I have met in the 14 years since, have obviously exaggerated sizes, with some claiming worms as large as our old world Perth trains. I've yet to meet a proper survivor of course – one with appendages missing from a worm attack – though everyone you meet has heard of them, or claims to

have. Heck even I claim to have met a few when asked. It's what passes for hopeful messaging these days I suppose – the lie that surviving a worm encounter is possible.

It's been 2 hours. My legs are white hot and have fallen asleep, but I still peel my ears trying to hear a sound. I shift my body around slowly, trying to get into a new position and hopefully restart circulation to my legs. Still silent. I play with my locket.

I awake with a start. Instantly jolted into hyperawareness.

The birds are singing, as dawn breaks. The Kookaburras are in fine voice today, and the parakeets are waking up to have a scrap in the trees. I remember in the old world how many of us used to hate these birds and their cacophony, waking us up before dawn. Now they were just distracting enough to the worms' senses so that we humans could move about stealthily.

I slid into the back seat of the rusty SUV, and tried to pry open the door handle as softly as I could. Nothing! Child locked! I try the other side, same thing. Cursing in my head I move to the front passenger seat. As I let myself out of the car, I know I have moved around way too much inside. I need to find another hiding spot, and soon. I move as silently and as fast as I can, away from the SUV, towards another cluster of cars about 100 metres away. I get there in about 15 minutes, they're all rust buckets too, and not fit to hide in. There is a backpack with some canned food near one of them though; six cans is about a month of rations, I feel elated.

I walk quietly towards the next set of cars, and then it happens. The old backpack rips, the cans clatter on to the road, I feel a dull rumbling followed by high pitched scraping. I freeze. The birds are singing up a crescendo now, egging the worm on as the crowds did the gladiators in the old, old world. This is it? This is how I die? I turn slowly to face my killer...

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